1.2 From Different Countries

You can probably think of a time when you were assigned a tough or boring task you didn't want to do. For some immigrants, only the hardest, lowest-paid work was available when they arrived in their new country.

MAIN IDEA Many immigrants came to the United States to escape food shortages and political conflicts in their home countries.

ESCAPING DISEASE AND POVERTY

Between the 1830s and 1860s, Irish immigrants represented the largest number of newcomers to the United States. Most were poor farmers who had no opportunities to improve their lives in their homeland. For centuries, Britain had claimed sovereignty over Ireland, and many of the Irish were dissatisfied with the oppression of British rule. To make matters worse, the country was experiencing widespread starvation due to the Great Irish Famine. A **famine** is an extreme shortage of food. From 1845 to 1852, a plant disease called **blight** killed the country's entire potato crop. The famine was made worse by the system of farming imposed by the British, because British landlords took what little food the Irish were able to farm. Approximately 1 million people died before the famine was over. For these reasons, or push factors, Irish immigrants came to the United States in record numbers.

Opportunities for jobs and new beginnings were pull factors for many Irish immigrants. American



CRITICAL VIEWING In 1850, British artist Frederick Goodall painted *An Irish Eviction.* He drew upon his experience of traveling in Ireland during the famine. Landlords eager to rid their lands of destitute laborers and farmers evicted hundreds of thousands of families. What details in Goodall's painting capture the despair of evicted tenants during the famine?

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business owners recruited Irish immigrants because they would work for lower wages than many American workers. While skilled workers such as carpenters or bakers could earn adequate wages, most Irish men were unskilled. They found jobs building railroads, digging canals, and loading cargo onto ships. The work was difficult, dangerous, and paid the lowest wages. For Irish women, unskilled labor meant **domestic service**, or housework in another person's home. Maids and kitchen servants received about a dollar a day in 1870, which was better pay than most factories offered. Plus, domestic service often included food and housing.

Immigrants brought their possessions in large trunks. This handmade wooden trunk with rope handles belonged to a Swedish immigrant.



British immigrants didn't flee from famine, but they did hope to escape from the rigid British class system. Just as in Irish society, few opportunities existed for British farmers to avoid living in poverty. From their perspective, owning inexpensive and fertile American land was a chance at a whole new, and likely better, life.

When they arrived in the United States, most British and Irish immigrants wanted to **assimilate**, or become part of, their new country. But they also held on to their culture and traditions. In the neighborhoods where they lived close to each other, they formed groups and clubs and attended community dances, meals, and church services together. Preserving and maintaining many of their customs and traditions offered a relief from the strain of assimilation.

MOVING TO THE MIDWEST

Poverty and hunger were not the only push factors. Civil unrest, or open conflict within a society, also encouraged people to leave. For example, in the middle of the 19th century, areas in Germany experienced a series of revolutions. As a result, many Germans fled to the United States.

German immigrants differed in some ways from other groups of immigrants. One difference was that Germans held diverse religious beliefs. Most German immigrants were Protestant, many others were Catholic or Jewish. Also, unlike those who came to escape poverty and famine, many German immigrants were not poor and did not have to travel in steerage. They could afford to continue traveling after they arrived in the country, oftentimes choosing to settle in the farmland between the present-day states of Nebraska and Minnesota. So many of them settled in this region, in fact, that the area became known as the "German Belt."

Especially after the 1860s, immigrants from Sweden, Norway, and Denmark joined the Germans in the upper Midwest. The population of Sweden was growing, farmland was scarce, and the same potato blight that hit Ireland struck Sweden around 1868. Some Swedes and other Scandinavian immigrants sought land in the United States. Others came for the growing number of well-paid factory jobs in midwestern cities such as Chicago and Minneapolis. Immigration increased the population and enriched the culture of the United States, but not all Americans welcomed the newcomers.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What factors prompted people to emigrate from their home countries?
2. **SYNTHESIZE** What pull factor drew so many different groups to the United States between 1830 and 1860?
3. **MAKE GENERALIZATIONS** What kinds of choices could wealthier immigrants make once they arrived in the United States?

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